conclusion that it was all the fault of witches. The more data the witch-hunters gathered, the more convinced they became that the world was full of demons and sorcery and that there was a global satanic conspiracy to destroy humanity. The information network then went on to identify the witches and imprison or kill them. We now know that witches were a bogus intersubjective category, invented by the information network itself and then imposed on people who had never actually met Satan and couldn't summon hailstorms.

In the Soviet Union, an even more elaborate information network invented the kulaks – another mythic category that was imposed on millions. The mountains of information collected by Soviet bureaucracy about the kulaks weren't an objective truth, but they created a new intersubjective truth. Knowing that someone was a kulak became one of the most important things to know about a Soviet person, even though the category was fictitious.

On an even larger scale, from the sixteenth to the twentieth century, numerous colonial bureaucracies in the Americas, from Brazil through Mexico and the Caribbean to the United States, created a racist mythology and came up with all kinds of intersubjective racial categories. Humans were divided into Europeans, Africans and Native Americans, and since interracial sexual relations were common, additional categories were invented. In many Spanish colonies the laws differentiated between *mestizos*, people with mixed Spanish and Native American ancestry; *mulatos*, people with mixed Spanish and African ancestry; *zambos*, people with mixed African and Native American ancestry; and *pardos*, people with mixed Spanish, African and Native American ancestry. All these seemingly empirical categories determined whether people could be enslaved, enjoy political rights, bear arms, hold public office, be admitted to school, practise certain professions, live in particular neighbourhoods and be allowed to have sex with and get married to each other. Allegedly, by placing a person in a particular racial drawer, one could define their personality, intellectual abilities and ethical inclinations.[53]

By the nineteenth century, racism pretended to be an exact science: it claimed to differentiate between people on the basis of objective biological facts, and to rely on scientific methods such as measuring skulls and recording crime statistics. But the cloud of numbers and categories was just a smokescreen for absurd intersubjective myths. The fact that somebody